Chapter 1

Never Say Die:
Striding Forward Persistently

RAJ PATH, NEW DELHI, THE ROAD LEADING FROM INDIA GATE (a First World War martyrs' memorial) to the palatial and stately Rashtrapati Bhavan, the President's Estate, was dressed in its resplendent best. It always is on the occasion of the Republic Day celebrations, beginning with one of the most impressive parades one can witness anywhere in the world, on 26 January, each year. (This splendid building houses the Indian president, and in the British era, it was the residence of the viceroy, then the most powerful man in the subcontinent.) The year 1975 was no different in that respect. What did make it different was that the march past by the contingent of the Delhi Police (which later won the prize for the best performance) was being led by a woman, Kiran Bedi (the first woman from the officer ranks of the elite Indian Police Service), for the first time in the history of this organization. So impressive was this young new entrant's performance that the prime minister of India, Mrs Indira Gandhi, who was witnessing the parade, virtually jumped out of her seat with a sense of personal pride and joy. She pointed out to her honoured chief guest, Kenneth Kaunda, the president of Zambia, the young woman leading an all-male contingent, striding ahead with a naked sword in her hands and giving a sharp and perfect salute to the national flag. The following day Kiran Bedi received an invitation from the prime minister's house for breakfast with her.

Kiran would have not had this rare first-ever privilege for an Indian woman in 1975 (which also coincided with the International Year of the Woman, as declared by the United Nations) if she had not held firm to her grit and total confidence in what she could do, based on the firm personal convictions she had grown up with. Kiran had no hesitation at all in going straight to the highest levels of the hierarchy to ask the top boss upfront why she was being overlooked to lead the parade when, as per seniority, it was her prerogative to do so. Her conversation with her boss, as narrated by Kiran, was as follows:

Kiran: 'Sir, I learn I'm not leading the parade?'

Boss: 'Look Kiran, it's a 15-kilometre march. And you'll have to do it with that heavy sword in hand. Can you?'

Kiran: 'After all the heavy training I've undergone, Sir, how long more will I have to continue to answer such questions?'

Upon this response, her top boss, P. R. Rajagopal (inspector general of police) was left without any reason to hold her back …. Kiran Bedi did lead the parade.

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A few years later, on 5 November 1979, the same Raj Path staged an awe-inspiring drama. Hundreds of Akali Sikhs in flowing kurtas, with cross-belts holding empty scabbards and swords in